Conclusion

Two decades later, Atal Behari Vajpayee would be back in Delhi's South Block—this time not as foreign minister, but as prime minister. Since his premiership—and the presidency of George W. Bush—China has had a starring role in the story of US-India relations. But, as this book has demonstrated, China played a major part in the US-India script much before that. Between 1949 and 1979 it was always there, if not on stage, then lurking in the wings and in the two lead characters' minds.

In the four decades after 1979, the nature of American and Indian interactions with China changed, not least because of a changing China. That Asian power continued to have an impact on the US-India relationship. Between 1979 and 1999, when US administrations saw China largely as a strategic and economic partner, Delhi saw Washington strengthening its major rival and helping elevate China's role globally and regionally. Furthermore, Indian policymakers found some aspects of Sino-US cooperation at the time particularly problematic for their own interests. In the 1980s, Beijing and Washington worked together with Islamabad after the Soviet invasion of Afghanistan, in the process strengthening the Pakistani military. Moreover, Delhi felt it resulted in Washington looking the other way as China assisted Pakistan's nuclear program. Then, as India sought an independent nuclear deterrent, it found Beijing and Washington together opposing it. In 1998, Vajpayee's Bharatiya Janata Party–led coalition government was particularly chagrined by the joint Sino-US criticism of India's nuclear tests.

But the reason that Vajpayee gave President Bill Clinton for those tests—the threat from China—was also a crucial reason why his government sought to repair relations with Washington despite posttest American sanctions on India. The US could be important to India's external and